

citizenry, one with a surprisingly optimistic outlook on the world. For them, for us, for India now, we need and shall want a nationalism of hope, one that asks for our allegiant belief by speaking to our economic possibilities and predicaments, rather than provoking our cultural and religious insecurities.

As the shards of the political turmoil and the fruits of economic growth of the last 35 years collide in uneven and unexpected ways, what is clear is our need for a new social contract. This should be able to define not just the relationship between state and citizen, but also connect each of our diverse and differently-favoured parts and give them reasons to want to stay joined with, and to contribute to the continual rebuilding and renewal. Such a new social contract can only emerge through politics—through argument, negotiation and persuasion.

One line pressed strongly in recent times has been to say we should wash our hands off our politicians (a plague upon both their houses), of political ideas, and even of politics itself and instead place our faith in economic growth and market dispensations to compensate for the failures of elected political leadership. But even as our economy progresses, we shall continue to live in a world, both global and local, of scarcity, one that will require clear-eyed judgements about distributional questions. Who gets how much of what and why? Such questions can never be economic or technical ones. They are always questions of ethics and politics, and to help decide them, a larger conception—of ourselves as society, of our principles, of our ends, of our reasons for persisting with the idea of India—is essential

What we see today in the political field is ideological torpor and intellectual timidity. The ideologies of the Left (communism) and of the religious right (Hindutva) have proved themselves empty as ways of thinking about what sort of society we might hope to be. The Congress, on the other hand, proud of its non-ideological character, is struggling to find an existence as a political party rather than a family placement unit. It is without a big national story to tell.

Congress has tried in piecemeal ways to put forward the elements of a new social contract (the NREGS for instance). But it has been unable to articulate a progressive, Indian social democracy, one that is committed to democracy, the market, and an intelligent, effective state guided by a practical conception of

social justice. Such a vision would have at its core not a tangle of policies which basically distribute the heaped gains of the state through the patronage systems of reservations and subsidies, but rather the real education of the citizenry. This is the greatest key to opportunity in the world we are entering: and it is also the only possible way in which numbers, our electoral democracy, might hope to be aligned with reason, the society and values that we might wish our electoral democracy to actually achieve.

In light of the domestic focus, there is one lesson we might draw from the experience of the past 35 years. It concerns the dangers of inwardness. As our politics left us preoccupied by vast internal problems, we became

mere observers of the global upheavals of the period, from the realignment of the geopolitical order to the radical change in the character of our regional neighbourhood.

In global terms, the span between 1975 and 2009 was bracketed by two events that mark the limits of American global power: the

retreat from Vietnam in 1975, and the ongoing American entrapment in Iraq and Afghanistan. In 1979, China began the reforms that have made it the fastest-rising power in world history. The Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, also in 1979, was the first pulled thread in the unraveling of the greatest utopian illusion of our time—the Soviet Union. Also starting in 1979

(there is a history of that year waiting to be written) was a major transformation in our region, still under way, in the character of Muslim societies and states—the revolution in Iran, Zia's acquisition of power in Pakistan, the rise of the Mujahideen resistance in Afghanistan, and the wider circulation of Saudi money to spread sectarian interpretations of Islamic doctrine.

These major international developments are still playing themselves out, and are hugely consequential for our present and future. When they began, and for most of the past three-and-a-half decades, we as a society did not analyse and reflect upon these shifts and what they might mean for us. We merely reacted when they impinged on us. It was a mistake then. It would be more of one now. Even as we seek to educate our democracy and make it more reasonable, even as we seek to work out a national compact that integrates economic progress and its often divisive effects into a larger, common political story, we shall need also to stay vigilant and focused on the threats and invitations, fugitive and more permanent, that the wider world holds in store for us.

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